TABLETOP EXERCISE
External Chemical Spill

Use these questions to guide discussion with regard to the following events:

1. What should classroom teachers be doing now?
2. What actions do you take with your students at this time?
3. What is the status of school emergency response teams at this time?
4. Where is your command post at this time?
5. What transition in the incident command system is taking place now? How?
6. What information do you need?
7. What action can you take to get the needed information?
8. What information to provide to the staff, students, parents, media, etc.?

H hour: A train derails and crashes against vehicles and buildings before coming to rest. Several railroad crossings in the community are blocked.

H hour + 1 minute: There is a tanker car leaking a yellowish gas. The temperature is 40 degrees Fahrenheit outside, the sky is overcast, and the air is still with occasional light breeze from the west.

H hour + 2 minute: The gas is hovering close to the ground. As the leaking gas spreads away from the rail car, people can be seen gasping, then holding their breath and attempting to run out of the area. Some are overcome and collapse to the ground.

H hour + 3 minutes: Staff members inside the building are coughing, suffering from shortness of breath, experiencing a burning sensation in the throat and nasal passage, and complaining of headaches.

H hour + 6 minutes: Media has begun reporting on the train derailment. Family members begin to call school office to check on the status.

H hour + 10 minutes: A Missouri Highway patrolman is on the scene and assumes incident command. Arriving law enforcement and emergency responders have begun to establish an outer perimeter one mile in all directions from the accident site. Fire trucks and ambulances are enroute from surrounding communities.

©Georgia School Boards Association

H hour + 11 minutes: There are two bodies on the ground outside the school. One can be recognized as a school district employee. That individual appears to be unconscious and perhaps dead. The other is still moving.

H hour + 15 minutes: A decision is made by the incident commander to relocate some students/staff further from the release site.

H hour + 25 minutes: The initial media briefing opens with this news release from the incident command:
What should be announced?

Conclude the exercise with an After Action Review:

- What did we do well?
- What could we do better next time?
- What changes should we make in our plan?

©Georgia School Boards Association